AI Playbook and Toolkit for Public Health Departments

AI-Supported Community Education and Outreach

HED 120

This module helps public health staff use AI responsibly when planning community education and outreach. It emphasizes community context, audience needs, cultural humility, partnership, and review of AI-generated outreach materials. The module is designed for agencies that may use different approved AI tools, so it focuses on process, safeguards, and approved-tool awareness rather than any single platform.

Level	applied
Primary track	Health Education Track
Appears in tracks	health-education

Learning Objectives

- Describe how AI can support community education planning without replacing community partnership or local knowledge.
- Identify risks when AI-generated outreach plans overlook community context, trust, access barriers, language needs, or historical harms.
- Apply a structured process for using AI to draft outreach messages, event plans, talking points, or audience-specific materials.
- Develop a community education outreach plan that includes AI-use safeguards and human review.

Module Overview

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Jurisdiction and Agency Policy Note

This national-level training module is intended for public health education, planning, and workforce development. It does not replace agency policy, legal review, privacy review, security review, procurement review, communications clearance, civil rights review, Tribal consultation, or governance approval. Learners should confirm applicable requirements, approved tools, data rules, and review pathways within their own jurisdiction and organization before implementing AI-supported workflows.

Why This Topic Matters for Public Health AI

Community education and outreach depend on trust, relationships, and local context. AI can help organize ideas, adapt messages, generate talking points, and create draft outreach plans, but it does not know the lived experience of a community unless appropriate community input is included. If AI-generated outreach materials are used without review, they may miss barriers such as transportation, disability access, digital access, language access, fear of government, immigration concerns, or prior experiences with public systems. Responsible use requires treating AI as a support tool, not as a substitute for community engagement.

Public health agencies often work with community partners who understand how messages are received, which channels are trusted, and what practical supports are needed. AI can help staff prepare for partner conversations by organizing options and drafting materials, but partners should still have the opportunity to shape the outreach approach. This is especially important for programs serving communities that have experienced stigma, underinvestment, surveillance, discrimination, or other harms. Outreach plans should document how community input will be requested, used, and reflected back.

Public Health Example

A health department is planning outreach about childhood immunization clinics in neighborhoods with lower coverage. Staff use an approved AI tool to draft outreach talking points for schools, faith-based partners, and family service organizations. Before using the drafts, the team asks community partners to review tone, access barriers, likely concerns, and preferred communication channels. The final outreach plan adds evening hours, transportation information, translated materials, and a partner FAQ because community review showed that the original AI-assisted plan focused too much on individual behavior and not enough on practical access.

Technical, Programmatic, and Operational Deep Dive

AI can support outreach planning by generating first drafts, segmenting possible audiences, suggesting message variations, and helping staff turn program goals into practical outreach steps. However, AI should be prompted to work from approved public health facts, program parameters, and community-informed assumptions. Staff should avoid asking AI to infer community needs from stereotypes or incomplete data. If staff do not have current community input, the outreach plan should include a step to obtain it rather than asking AI to fill the gap.

An AI-supported outreach workflow should include a clear review sequence. Program staff should confirm service details, communications staff should review public language, equity or community engagement staff should review assumptions and access barriers, and community partners should review whether the approach is respectful and feasible. Language-access and accessibility needs should be planned early, not added at the end. The workflow should also identify what feedback will be collected after outreach begins.

Responsible AI use in outreach also requires transparency within the project team. Staff should know whether AI helped draft materials, what source information was used, and what human edits were made. If an AI-generated idea is rejected because it does not fit the community, that learning should be documented. This helps teams improve prompts, refine review checklists, and avoid repeating problematic assumptions.

Risks, Failure Modes, and Guardrails

A major failure mode is allowing AI to generate outreach strategies based on broad demographic labels rather than specific community knowledge. This can produce messages that feel generic, stigmatizing, or disconnected from real barriers. Guardrails include partner review, community-informed assumptions, and documentation of what local knowledge shaped the final plan. Staff should be careful not to treat race, ethnicity, income, geography, or language as shortcuts for community preferences.

Another risk is using AI to analyze community comments, meeting notes, or survey responses in an unapproved tool. Community feedback may contain sensitive information, names, locations, concerns about services, or information that could affect trust if mishandled. Staff should only use approved tools and approved data handling processes for community feedback. Summaries should preserve dissent, uncertainty, and context rather than smoothing feedback into a single artificial consensus.

A third risk is overproducing messages without evaluating whether outreach actually improved access or understanding. AI can make it easy to create many flyers, posts, scripts, or FAQs, but quantity is not the same as impact. Programs should track whether outreach reached the intended audience, whether people understood the information, whether barriers were reduced, and whether partners found the materials useful. This turns AI-supported outreach into an improvement process rather than a content-production exercise.

Application to AI-Supported Workflows

This module applies to AI-supported workflows that generate outreach plans, partner talking points, community education materials, event scripts, FAQs, or audience-specific messages. The workflow should require approved source material, no-sensitive-data safeguards, human review, partner review when appropriate, and a feedback loop. AI can help staff prepare options, but humans must decide which options are respectful, feasible, and aligned with public health goals. The final plan should document community input and how it changed the approach.

Reflection Questions

Where could AI help your team prepare community education materials without replacing community partnership?

Which communities, partners, or reviewers should be involved before outreach materials are used?

What community feedback should be collected after AI-assisted outreach materials are deployed?

Practical Exercise

Create a one-page AI-supported outreach planning template for a public health education topic. Include the target audience, public health purpose, approved facts, trusted partners, access barriers, language and accessibility needs, community review process, AI-use safeguards, and feedback measures.

Example: For a diabetes prevention outreach campaign, the template might identify community health workers and food access partners as reviewers, require plain-language materials in the languages used locally, prohibit the use of real participant stories in AI prompts, and track attendance, questions, referral uptake, and partner feedback after outreach events.

Expected Artifact or Evidence

AI-supported community outreach planning template.

Brief explanation of how community input will be obtained and used.

List of safeguards for approved tools, sensitive data, and human review.

Knowledge Check

- 1. What should AI not replace in community outreach planning?
- 2. Which is an appropriate AI use in outreach planning?
- 3. Why should community partners review AI-assisted outreach materials?
- 4. What is a risk of broad demographic prompting?
- 5. What should be documented after community review?

References and Resources

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